Season 3: Truth Behind the Walls

Attack on Titan - Detailed Season Summary (Episodes 38-59)

Season: 3 (two parts) | **Episodes:** 22 (series episodes 38-59) | **Original run:** July 2018 - July 2019

Story arcs: Part 1 - Coup d'etat and the Reiss family; Part 2 - Return to Shiganshina and the basement

Key characters: Eren Yeager, Historia Reiss, Rod Reiss, Kenny Ackerman, Levi, Erwin Smith, Armin Arlert, Reiner Braun, Bertholdt Hoover, Zeke (Beast Titan)

Spoiler warning: this document summarises the anime in full, including major twists and the ending of the season described.

1. Season Overview

Season 3 is the longest and most plot-heavy season of the series so far and is split into two parts. Part 1 (the Reiss and Coup d'etat arc) is a political thriller in which the Survey Corps fights the corrupt government and discovers the truth about the royal family. Part 2 (the Return to Shiganshina arc) is a large-scale war story in which the Survey Corps attempts to retake Wall Maria and finally reach the basement of Eren's home. The season ends with the revelation of the true history of the world, which changes everything the characters thought they knew.

2. Major Characters in Season 3

Eren Yeager, **Mikasa Ackerman** and **Armin Arlert** continue at the centre of the story. **Levi Ackerman** faces his past through his former mentor **Kenny Ackerman**, leader of the Military Police's Anti-Personnel Control Squad. **Erwin Smith** orchestrates a coup and later leads the final charge at Shiganshina. **Hange Zoe** acts as the Corps' scientific mind. **Historia Reiss** discovers her royal blood. **Rod Reiss** is the secret true ruler of the walls and her father. **Frieda Reiss** is her half-sister and the previous holder of the Founding Titan. **Reiner Braun**, **Bertholdt Hoover** and the **Beast Titan** (Zeke Yeager) are the enemy shifters. **Dot Pixis**, **Nile Dok** and **Darius Zackly** represent the military's various factions. **Jean Kirstein**, **Connie Springer** and **Sasha Braus** fight beside their friends throughout the season.

3. Detailed Plot Summary - Part 1: The Reiss and Coup d'etat Arc

Arc 1 - Smoke Signal and the New Levi Squad

After the events at Utgard, the Survey Corps is under suspicion. Erwin forms a new Levi Squad around Eren and his friends and attempts to find a safe place to hide Eren and Historia. But the Military Police's Anti-Personnel Control Squad, led by Kenny Ackerman, starts hunting the Corps, killing several members. Erwin is arrested on suspicion of treason. Levi realises Kenny is the man who raised him in the Underground, and the confrontation becomes personal.

Arc 2 - Historia's Past and the Coup

Historia's backstory is revealed in an episode called Old Story. She grew up on a farm in Wall Rose with a cruel mother, and one day Rod Reiss, her father, arrived and told her that she was his illegitimate daughter. Kenny was sent to kill her and her mother. Her mother died, but Historia survived, and later took the name Krista Lenz to hide. Now Rod Reiss wants her to take the throne and to use Eren's power. Meanwhile, Erwin's allies, with the help of Pixis, Nile and Zackly, stage a nearly bloodless coup d'etat in which they overthrow the puppet king and reveal the corruption of the government. Historia is set to be crowned as the

real queen.

Arc 3 - Rod Reiss's Plan

Kenny delivers Eren and Historia to Rod Reiss in a hidden chapel. Rod explains that the Reiss family holds the Founding Titan, a power that was used by Frieda before she died, and that this power has been lost. He wants Historia to inherit the Founding Titan by eating Eren, who holds it now, though she refuses because she does not want to be used by him or to kill her friend. Rod instead takes the serum himself and transforms into a gigantic Titan, but the transformation produces a monstrous, deformed giant. His enormous Titan form crawls toward the walls, threatening the Orvud District. The Survey Corps, the Garrison and the Military Police work together to protect the district. After a difficult fight, the Titan is destroyed. Kenny, mortally wounded in his battle with Levi, speaks to him about the Ackerman family and gives him his vial of Titan serum before he dies. Historia is crowned queen and decides to rule for her people instead of as her father wanted.

4. Detailed Plot Summary - Part 2: The Return to Shiganshina Arc

Arc 4 - Operation to Retake Wall Maria

With the government in new hands, the Survey Corps prepares to retake Wall Maria and reach the basement of Eren's home. The night before the operation, the soldiers share a feast and talk about their hopes. In the morning they advance toward Shiganshina District. They discover that the enemy has set a trap: Reiner and Bertholdt are waiting, joined by the Beast Titan, who commands a horde of Titans. Armin has anticipated a trap and has designed a counter-plan.

Arc 5 - Thunder Spears and the Battle of Shiganshina

The Corps uses a new weapon called Thunder Spears, explosive harpoons that can pierce the Armored Titan's hardened skin. They injure Reiner badly and almost kill him. However, the Beast Titan throws boulders from afar and decimates the Corps, while the Colossal Titan appears to cover the district in fire. Erwin realises that the only way to win is to sacrifice most of the army. He leads a suicidal charge against the Beast Titan to draw its attention, while Levi uses the distraction to attack it from behind. The charge is a massacre, and almost every soldier dies, but it gives Levi time to take down the Beast Titan's defences and nearly kill its wielder. The Beast Titan escapes.

Arc 6 - Armin's Plan and Erwin's Death

Armin proposes a risky plan to lure the Colossal Titan into a trap with Eren's help and ends up gravely burned. Erwin, too, is mortally wounded. Levi has only one dose of the serum that can turn a person into a Titan or restore a dying person to life and must choose between saving Erwin, the commander whose dream led to so many deaths, or Armin, a young man with a rare mind. After a painful struggle, Levi decides to give the serum to Armin. Armin becomes a Titan, eats Bertholdt and takes the Colossal Titan's power. Reiner is left alone, and Erwin passes away, convinced that his sacrifice served a purpose.

Arc 7 - The Basement

After the battle ends, the survivors, including Eren, Mikasa, Levi, Hange and Armin, enter the basement of Eren's home. They discover Grisha Yeager's journals and photographs. The truth is revealed: there is a world beyond the walls and an ocean, and the Titans are the descendants of an ancient people, the Eldians. The Eldians were once rulers of the world, but the country of Marley now oppresses them, and the island of Paradis, where the walls stand, is the only place where they are free. The people inside the walls are Eldians too, and the Titans are a weapon born from their own blood. The season ends with Eren, Mikasa

and Armin realising that the world outside considers them devils, that their fight is much larger than they believed, and that the real enemy may not be the Titans at all.

5. Key Revelations of Season 3

(1) Historia is the illegitimate daughter of Rod Reiss, the secret king, and the Reiss family holds the Founding Titan. (2) The Ackerman family is a lineage with special abilities, and Levi and Mikasa are Ackermans. (3) The government was hiding the truth about the walls and the memory-altering power behind them. (4) The Survey Corps uses Thunder Spears to defeat the Armored Titan, and Armin inherits the Colossal Titan. (5) Grisha Yeager, Eren's father, was not a simple doctor: he came from outside the walls and used the Attack Titan. (6) The world outside the walls is real, and Eldians are persecuted by Marley as descendants of devils.

6. How the Story Progresses

The first half of the season proves that the story is as much about politics, power and secrets as it is about monsters. The second half proves that the heroes' dream of finding the truth about the basement may not bring them hope. The final episode reveals that humanity's enemies are living beings with their own reasons, and that Eren's country is a prison island in a larger world. This opens the door to Season 4, in which the story moves outside the walls, shifts perspective to the Marleyan side and questions who is truly the hero and who is the villain.